Movie Maverick: 100 Years of Roger Corman

Roger Corman's Frankenstein Unbound

Roger Corman's Frankenstein Unbound
Director: Roger Corman
©: Byron Films Inc
Production Company: Mount Company
Producers: Roger Corman, Thom Mount, Kobi Jaeger
Associate Producers: Laura J. Medina, Jay Cassidy
Unit Production Managers: Laura J. Medina, Luciano Balducci
Unit Manager (2nd Unit): Massimo Cortesi
Unit Manager: Bruno Mancinelli
Production Co-ordinator: Anne Nevin
US Production Office Co-ordinator: Thomas 'Doc' Boguski
Italian Production Services: Panda Film
Production Controller: Robert C. Campion
Production Accountant: Angelo Sarago
Location Manager: Roberto Gallarati
2nd Unit Director: Thierry Notz
1st Assistant Director: Tony Brandt
2nd Assistant Director: Mauro Sacripanti
3rd Assistant Director: Simona Bares
Script Supervisor: Clarita Digiovanni
Casting: Caro Jones
Casting (Rome): John Leamer
Casting (London): Karen Lindsay-Stewart
Screenplay: Roger Corman, F.X. Feeney
Screenplay: Edward Neumeier *
Based on the novel 'Frankenstein Unbound' by: Brian W. Aldiss
Directors of Photography: Armando Nannuzzi, Michael Scott
Camera Operator: Hans Visser
Camera (2nd Unit): Fabio Cianchetti, Andrea Treccani
Camera Assistants: Franco Rosignoli, Guido Sagramoso
Gaffer: Domenico Cavaliere
Key Grip: Mario Tessarin
Stills Photography: Keith Hamshere
Special Visual Effects: Bill Taylor, Syd Dutton
Visual Effects: Illusion Arts, Fantasy Film Effects
Set Special Effects: Renato Agostini
Computer Animation/Displays: Video Image, Rhonda Gunner, Richard Hollander, Gregory L. McMurry, John C. Wash
Editors: Jay Cassidy, Mary Bauer
Production Designer: Enrico Tovaglieri
Set Decorator: Ennio Michettoni
Storyboard Artists: Keith Crossley, Barbara Anne Bock
Property Master: Giuseppe Mancarella
Costume Designer: Franca Zucchelli
Make-up Artist: Guiliana Decarli
Special Make-up Effects: Nick Dudman
The Monster Created by: Nick Dudman
Prosthetic Make-up Artist: Suzanne Reynolds
Foam Latex Supervisor: Reza Karim
Animatronics Engineer: Ian Whittaker
Prosthetic Mould Design: Raymond Tricker
Hairstylist: Romana Piolanti
Main Titles Backgrounds: Oxford Scientific Films Ltd
Colour Timer: Phil Hetos
Music: Carl Davis
Orchestrations: Nic Raine
Music Editor: Bob Hathaway
Sound Mixer: Gary Alper
Re-recording Mixers: Ken S. Polk, Ken Teaney
Dialogue Editor: Terri Fiyalko

By his beginnings will we know him. One of the pleasures of *Roger Corman's Frankenstein Unbound*, now that credit sequences are becoming so starkly informational, is that it begins with a sequence which encapsulates and abstracts its theme, and is also quite beautiful in its own right. A swirl of matter is soon identifiable as Promethean fire, the sun's flames in close-up; this then becomes incandescent matter of another kind, particles streaming in a void or floating in a primal jelly, as if the telescopic view had suddenly become a microscopic one.

In the credit sequences of Corman's 60s films, nothing was really identifiable, presumably because economy dictated that these vistas of cellular life spawning, replicating, mutating across the screen were handmade approximations. But the effects were striking: an obvious contagion a-borning in *The Masque of the Red Death*, and something more luxuriously, liquidly suggestive – blood, spermatozoa – in the colours squirting into each other for *Pit and the Pendulum*. The effect there was even slightly psychedelic, anticipating *The Trip*, a largely plotless film which was like a feature-length credit sequence.

The opening of *Frankenstein Unbound*, however, is the real thing, scientific film footage which, like the well-rounded, classically ominous score by Carl Davis, announces that this is not the cheap and cheerful context of the Corman of old. For his return to directing after the 20-year hiatus since *Von Richthofen and Brown*, the maker of two- and three-day wonders had the luxury of a ten-week schedule and a $9m budget on locations around Milan and Lake Como. But how much figurative realism, how much authentic scene-setting, can a Corman movie stand?

There is one curious trial scene, for instance, set in Geneva in 1817, in which a young girl is accused of having, with the aid of witchcraft, horribly dismembered the younger brother of Dr Victor Frankenstein (Raul Julia), whose own monster of course did the deed. The trial is observed by a time-tripping scientist from the 21st century, Dr Joe Buchanan (John Hurt), who casually joins the crowds flocking to the courtroom, Corman's happily mobile camera following him on a tour of the solid period setting (Bergamo Alta for Geneva) and its bustling inhabitants. But once the trial is under way, with its grumbling peasants and American-accented officials, we might well be in a more hastily stuck-together, and more playful, witchcraft and time-travel caper like *The Undead* (1956).

Frankenstein Unbound is certainly playful, from its outright jokes – at home in New Los Angeles, Joe Buchanan zips around in a computerised car with a bar code instead of a licence plate – to a plot which allows the foresighted Buchanan to discuss Mary Shelley's as yet unwritten *Frankenstein* with the author (Bridget Fonda), while Frankenstein and his creature are running around the woods in the flesh. One could not, in fact, ask for anything more in the way of a compleat Corman, beginning with the imperious figure of Joe Buchanan, tinkering with the way space and time are put together to suit his own designs. In 2031, he has invented a laser beam which can cause targets to implode,

Digital Sound Effects Designer: Harry Cohen
Digital Sound Effects Editors: Tim Gedemer, Ann Scibelli, Greg Hodge
Stunt Co-ordinator: Paul Weston
Special Thanks: Danny Bramson, Ed Neumeier
Stereo Consultant: Bruce Murphy
Unit Publicist: Geoff Freeman
Cast:
John Hurt *(Dr Joseph Buchanan)*
Raul Julia *(Dr Victor Frankenstein)*
Bridget Fonda *(Mary Godwin Shelley)*
Catherine Rabett *(Elisabeth)*
Jason Patric *(Lord John Byron)*
Michael Hutchence *(Percy Shelley)*
Nick Brimble *(Monster)*
Catherine Corman *(Justine Moritz)*
William Geiger *(lab technician)*
Mickey Knox *(General Reade)*
Myriam Cyr *(information officer)*
Terri Treas *(computer voice)*
Cynthia Allison *(newswoman)*
Isabella Rocchietta *(Dorrie)*
Matt Cassidy *(boy no 1)*
Hauck Bjorck *(boy no 2 – on sandbag)*
Olga Angelo *(girl no 2)*
Geoffrey Copleston *(innkeeper)*
John Karlsen *(parson)*
Donald Hodson *(old man)*
Bruce McGuire *(prosecutor)*
Grady Clarkson *(judge)*
Andrew Newton *(head juror)*
Paul Weston *(watchman)*
Brian Ames *(urchin 1)*
Christopher Robertson *(urchin 2)*
Peter Goetz *(man no 1)*
Nick Gillard *(man no 2/man no 3)*
Cyrus Elias *(Werner)*
Ian Whittaker *(stablehand)* *
USA 1990
85 mins
35mm

35mm print courtesy of the
UCLA Film & Television Archive

* Uncredited

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Julie, Mary and Catherine Corman
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simply drop out of time, and this he demonstrates to the military ('Ladies and gentlemen, I give you the atom, new and improved') with the idea that now they'll be able to wage war without destroying the world. But his experiments have an unfortunate side effect, 'stratospheric disturbances' which are shaking the boundaries of this future perfect world, because when an object drops out of time, 'sometimes it leaves a door open'.

Joe is shortly whisked through this door, finding himself on a hillside in Switzerland (we know it's Switzerland because Davis' score gives out a few bars of the 'William Tell Overture': some effects here are still cheap and cheerful). He then meets Victor Frankenstein, who is intrigued by his digital watch and peppermint-flavoured envelopes ('We are brothers, doctor'), makes the acquaintance of Byron and Shelley, a fey pair who simper at each other and make jokes about sex and death, and tries unsuccessfully to save the wrongly accused girl, Justine, from hanging. Finally, to repair his damage to space and time, and to try to stop Frankenstein from committing a comparable folly, Buchanan collaborates in an experiment that shoots them all through time again. This lands them in a snowy waste, true to Mary Shelley, where, true to Corman, Buchanan is seen at the beginning and end of the film, 'either at the end of a world or the beginning of one', trudging after the monster, who represents 'the madness of possibility' (Mary's words here) unbound.

The Frankenstein theme so neatly describes everything Corman has done – from such previously Promethean figures as Doctor Xavier and Prince Prospero, to the very way he made his films by stitching together other people's leftovers – that it's surprising he has not treated the character before. And *Frankenstein Unbound* is 'omnibus' enough to include many scenes of unreconstructed '60s Corman, from Buchanan's tinted dream sequences – bloody hands grope after the stumbling scientist, as he confronts a grinning, hooded figure with the question, 'Who is responsible for this?', and is told, 'Who do you think?' – to the drive-in sex and badly acted ingenue scenes with Mary Shelley ('Percy and Byron preach free love, I practise it,' she purrs, unbuttoning her bodice for Joe).

This is exploitation, though, without the dangerous edge of 50s and 60s Corman, the kind of insane inventiveness inspired by shaky sets, overnight scripts and impossible schedules. Here it has the more slickly knowing, processed quality of the New World product – Buchanan's car, with its cute female persona ('Be a good girl,' he tells it; 'My options are limited,' it replies), is a *Death Race 2000* model. The 'madness of possibility' has less resonance here because the possibilities of the film itself didn't have to be snatched out of thin air.

Richard Combs, *Sight and Sound*, Winter 1990-91